Pastoralists in the Modern World

The big idea

Pastoralists are people who rear and herd animals such as sheep, goats, camels and cattle. Many are **nomads**, who move from place to place with their herds in search of pasture. Their movements are not random; they are a clever adaptation to seasons and environment. Colonial rule, however, made their lives much harder in both **India** and **Africa**.

Pastoral nomads and their movements

Community	Region	Animals	Movement
Gujjar Bakarwals	Jammu and Kashmir	goats and sheep	Winter in the low hills of the **Siwalik** range; in April move north to summer pastures; groups called **kafila**
Gaddi shepherds	Himachal Pradesh	sheep	Winter in the low Siwalik hills; summer in **Lahul and Spiti** and higher meadows
Gujjar cattle herders	Garhwal and Kumaon	cattle	Winter in the dry forests of the **bhabar**; summer in high meadows called **bugyals**
Bhotiyas, Sherpas, Kinnauris	Himalayas	various	Similar cyclic seasonal movement
Dhangars	Maharashtra	sheep, buffaloes;	Monsoon in the central plateau (dry, semi-arid); after the October harvest move

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		some weave blankets	west to the **Konkan**, where farmers welcome their manure
Gollas, Kurumas, Kurubas	Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh	cattle, sheep and goats	Move between dry plateau (dry season) and wooded areas, coast (monsoon); some sold woven blankets
Banjaras	UP, Punjab, Rajasthan, MP, Maharashtra	cattle	Long journeys selling plough cattle and goods for grain and fodder
Raikas	Rajasthan desert	camels, goats (Maru Raikas)	Combine cultivation with herding; leave villages when monsoon pastures dry up

Why move? Movement allows pastures to **recover** (regenerate) and prevents overgrazing. Herders combine many activities: cultivation, trade and herding. They must judge how long to stay, where to find water and pasture, and maintain relationships with farmers along the way.

Colonial rule and pastoral life

Pastoralists' lives changed dramatically under colonial rule:

1. **Waste Land Rules:** the colonial state saw uncultivated land as "wasteland" that gave no revenue. From the mid-19th century **Waste Land Rules** were enacted; such land was given to select individuals for cultivation. Often this land was pastoral grazing land, so pasture shrank.
2. **Forest Acts:** by the mid-19th century forests that produced valuable timber (deodar, sal) were declared **Reserved**; pastoralists were barred. In **Protected** forests some grazing rights were allowed but movements were restricted. They needed permits and could stay only for a fixed number of days.

3. **Criminal Tribes Act (1871):** many communities of craftsmen, traders and pastoralists were classified as **criminal tribes**, "criminal by nature and birth". They had to live in notified village settlements and could not move without a permit; police watched them.
4. **Grazing tax:** introduced in the mid-19th century; tax per head of cattle. Pastoralists had to carry a pass; the right to collect tax was auctioned to contractors, who extracted high taxes.

How did they cope? Some reduced the number of cattle; others found new pastures (after **1947** some Raikas could no longer go to Sindh, now in Pakistan, and moved to Haryana where farmers welcomed them after harvest). Some bought land and settled; some, poorer ones, became labourers. Many continue to adapt, and still survive today.

Pastoralism in Africa

More than half the world's pastoral population lives in **Africa**: over **22 million** Africans depend on some form of pastoral activity. Communities include **Bedouins, Berbers, Maasai, Somali, Boran and Turkana**.

The Maasai live in **East Africa** (about 3,00,000 in southern **Kenya** and around 1,50,000 in **Tanzania**). Their name for themselves derives from *Maa*; "Maasai" means "my people".

- **Loss of land:** In **1885** Maasailand was cut in half by an international boundary between **British Kenya** and **German Tanganyika**. Maasai lost about **60%** of their pre-colonial land and were confined to arid zones with poor rainfall and pasture.
- **Game reserves:** large areas were turned into reserves such as the **Maasai Mara** and **Samburu National Park** (Kenya) and the **Serengeti National Park** (Tanzania, created over 14,760 sq km of Maasai grazing land), where pastoralists could not enter.
- **Drought:** confined to a fixed area, they could not move in drought. In 1933 and 1934 more than half the cattle in Maasai Reserve died.

- **Social changes:** traditionally society had **elders** (who decided disputes) and **warriors** (younger people who protected the tribe and organised cattle raids). The British appointed **chiefs** of different sub-groups and banned raiding and warfare, which weakened warriors' authority. Chiefs became wealthy, lent money and bought land, while poor pastoralists became labourers. The gap between rich and poor grew.

"WASTELAND" WAS NOT USELESS LAND

For the colonial state "wasteland" meant land that paid no revenue. For pastoralists it was vital grazing land. Use this contrast in your answer.

MAP POINT

On an outline map of India you may be asked to locate the regions of the Gujjar Bakarwals (Jammu and Kashmir), Gaddis (Himachal Pradesh), Dhangars (Maharashtra), Raikas (Rajasthan) and Gollas/Kurumas (Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh).

Quick recap

- Nomads move seasonally to let pastures recover; movement is planned, not random.
- Colonial laws hurt pastoralists: Waste Land Rules, Forest Acts, Criminal Tribes Act (1871), grazing tax.
- Pastoralists adapted by reducing herds, finding new pastures or settling.
- Maasai lost about 60% of land; game reserves and drought hurt them; British-appointed chiefs changed society.

Practice questions

1. The Dhangars are an important pastoral community of
   (a) Rajasthan (b) Jammu and Kashmir (c) Maharashtra (d) Karnataka
2. High-altitude meadows where Gujjar cattle herders of Garhwal graze in summer are called
   (a) bhabar (b) bugyals (c) kafila (d) Siwalik
3. The Criminal Tribes Act was passed in
   (a) 1857 (b) 1885 (c) 1947 (d) 1871
4. In 1885 Maasailand was divided between
   (a) British Kenya and German Tanganyika (b) French Kenya and British Tanzania (c) British Kenya and Portuguese Mozambique (d) German Kenya and British Uganda
5. Which community of Himachal Pradesh spends summer in Lahul and Spiti?
   (a) Raikas (b) Bhotiyas (c) Banjaras (d) Gaddis
6. Why did the colonial government introduce Waste Land Rules?
   (a) To protect wildlife (b) To turn uncultivated land into revenue-paying agricultural land (c) To help pastoralists find grazing (d) To build railways
7. Serengeti National Park was created on the grazing land of the
   (a) Gaddis (b) Bedouins (c) Maasai (d) Raikas
8. How did colonial rule affect the lives of pastoralists in India?
9. Why do nomadic tribes need to move from one place to another? What are the advantages of this movement to the environment?

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. d 4. a 5. d 6. b 7. c 8. see notes 9. see notes